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Herb Ellis

Herb Ellis demonstrates the idea of "minimum effort, maximum results." His melodic guitar playing has been an integral part of numerous classic jazz recordings, especially with the renown Oscar Peterson Trio of the 1950s. He was born in Texas in 1921, graduated from North Texas State, and found inspiration from Charlie Christian, another Texas guitarist. Previous to joining Oscar Peterson he played with Glen Grey, Jimmy Dorsey and the Soft Winds Trio. Herb often accompanied Ella Fitzgerald and recorded with fellow guitarists Joe Pass, Barney Kessel and Charlie Byrd. He makes his home in Arkansas and can be found at festivals and jazz venues across the country, occasionally with the Tonight Show Alumni Band.

Herb was interviewed by Michael Woods in Los Angeles on September 3, 1995.

MW: We are here today at the Marriott in Los Angeles filming interviews for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. We have with us today one of the world's most outstanding jazz guitarists, Herb Ellis. Pleased to meet you.

HE: Nice meeting you.

MW: Yes. I wanted to ask you some things about how you got started playing guitar.

HE: Oh, let me see. Well I first played the harmonica when I was three, so I'm told, and it must be true 'cause I can still play it a little bit, very little. And then my parents bought me a banjo when I was seven. And I learned to play that, and then somebody left a guitar at our house, and my older brother wanted to accompany me. So he'd tune the guitar incorrectly, you know. It would be hard to show you, but well it was a cheap shot. You'd connect the chords with just one finger, see? And so being an older brother he did everything much better than I did. So I saw that I had him, so I got a book from Sears Roebuck that said, "Learn to play the guitar in five minutes," and I believed it. So I learned to play it correctly and I showed him how to play, and so that was a good lift for me.

MW: Let me ask you about your experience at North Texas State.

HE: Oh, yeah, right. Well I went there let me see, in 1870 — almost. Wait a minute, 1941 and '42 I went there. And it was great. It's really gotten a lot larger now you know. And it's a very good school. And I roomed with a bunch of guys, we had a house together, and they were all musicians and all jazz players. So I actually learned more staying there with them, listening to all the records they had. So I learned some from school but we played, we had a drummer, a bassist, pianist, myself and a trumpet and a saxophone. So we played all the time you know, so that was a big help.

MW: With the, what did they have in the school systems at that time in terms of jazz studies?

HE: Well there were no jazz studies at all. We just, we all banded together and in music appreciation we were all good students so they would listen to us. And we asked if we could bring our jazz records in and play them along with the classical records, and they said okay. And with that we were instrumental with starting the jazz part at the school.

MW: Good, good. Tell us how you got started working with probably one of the greatest trios in all of jazz — Oscar Peterson and Ray Brown.

HE: I was playing, I had been with bands, I'd been with Jimmy Dorsey, and the three of us in Jimmy Dorsey's band, the bassist and the pianist and myself formed a trio, sort of a la Nat Cole, and we were playing in Buffalo. And we played in the same hotel for, oh months at a time. And the people from Canada, there was no liquor in Canada on Sundays at that time, but they'd come over for the music. And a lot of them came. And one night they brought Oscar Peterson with them. And he sat in and played with us and then after the job Oscar and I went out and we played in a different place. And from that meeting and playing together, about four years later, when he needed a guitarist for his group, he asked for me. And I was not that well known. He could have had anybody he wanted, but thank God he chose me.

MW: You know that says something about musicians striking a certain chemistry.

HE: That's true.

MW: Can you tell us other musicians that you've had that chemistry with?

HE: Oh let me see. Well there's a lot of them. I had it with Sweets Edison, he's here at the festival, you know. And I have it with Jake Hanna, the drummer. And of course I have it with Ray Brown to a great extent. We love to play together. So there could be more but I can't name them all.

MW: Could you also explain to guitarists how that it takes an impeccable sense of time to play in a trio with no drums.

HE: Yes it does. In a trio with no drums, for the guitarist you've got to work with the pianist you know, and the bassist of course. But playing with a piano I don't know if I'd categorize it as being very difficult but you have to learn how to keep out of each other's way you know? That's the main thing. Learning what not to play, which is a very important thing in music, in jazz music or any kind of music. Sometimes the best thing you'll do, the best music you'll make is something that you leave out. So I've tried to learn that.

MW: Accompanying is an art, isn't it?

HE: I would say it is. Well see I think I do it well because I love to accompany, see, I love to accompany people. I know a lot of guitarists and pianists too I suppose that they just like to solo. They really don't like to accompany, so consequently they don't do it very well.

MW: With this trio, tell us some of the maybe more humorous things that happened in the trio.

HE: Oh. All right. We were in Los Angeles here playing at some club, and we had Sunday we had off. So Ray and I, we roomed together and we'd play golf. And it was late in the afternoon so we had this idea. Well coming home from golf, and I saw this advertisement in a drug store, and it said, "Dye your hair any color" and then it would wash right out any time you wash your hair. So I had an idea, and Ray went for it but he was kind of leery about it. See I had bright red hair at the time, and Ray's was jet black. So he dyed his hair a bilious red. And I dyed mine black. And then we called Oscar and told him that we had to see him. And he said, "Well what do you have to see me for?" He said, "I'll see you tomorrow night." And so I said, "No, it's very important, we really have to see you." So he said, "Well okay." He said, "I'm on my way to dinner. I can't be long with you guys." And we said, "Just come by and we'll talk about it." So we're sitting there and Ray is reading the paper in his robe. And Oscar knocks, and I opened the door to let him in and there I am with that jet black hair and Ray with this bilious red hair. And he looks at me and he said, "Herb? Ray? What did you guys want to see me about?" I mean he didn't crack at all. Nothing. And we said, "Well don't you get it?" And he said, "The only thing I get is that you're making me late for dinner." That's composure. Wooo!

MW: How much is humor a part of the very fabric of jazz?

HE: Oh, I think it's a great part. And you can see a lot of players who don't put any humor in it. And you can tell. It's very sad. They play the notes but it's dreary you know. Humor and melancholy is nice, and you know sometimes a little sadness, but humor is, oh boy, I don't have any use for somebody who plays with no humor. It's very sterile you know.

MW: Tell us about some of your duo work with Joe Pass.

HE: Well God bless him. I loved him and he was my favorite guitarist and still is. And we had a way of playing. We could play, we knew how to back each other up, but then we could both play at the same time you know? You may have heard us do that. I mean both soloing at the same time. And that, I was going to say, could be difficult. It can be difficult but with him, we knew, we just fit with each other. But the reason, we're both very selfless you know — he towards my playing and I towards his playing. So when we would play those things where we were both playing at the same time — and that's dangerous territory — we could do it just like it was written out for us. Amazing.

MW: A kind of dialogue?

HE: Yes, exactly. That's a very good way to put it. Yeah.

MW: Now you played some behind Ella Fitzgerald. How is it different to accompany a singer, especially a great singer?

HE: Oh and she is the greatest. Ella, for instance when she was singing the verse to a tune, out of time you know, and you're playing for her, you just kind of have to tag after her. Because she goes right through it — bang you know. Now somebody like, oh I can't

think of the names but it doesn't matter, maybe I'll think of it later, sing way behind the beat. I mean way behind the beat. You've got to be tugging them, like with a rope you know. Not that it's bad, it's just that you have to learn how to do with each singer.

MW: About the time element, this tugging feeling, that is an essential part of jazz. Can you kind of describe that?

HE: The jazz beat you mean?

MW: As you know for instance with a lead player either pushing ahead on the beat or pulling behind as compared to the rhythm section.

HE: Oh, I see. Well in my opinion the rhythm section sounds best when the drummer plays right on the beat, and the bass is just a hair on top of that. Not enough that you get a [claps]. It's just a little edge. That's the way Ray Brown plays and other players too. And then the pianist, they just have to know what to leave out, and the guitarist has to learn how to play with the rhythm section but with the pianist. That's the thing. So you don't get in each other's way you know. So that's the way an optimum rhythm section would work for me. That's the optimum way it would work I mean to say.

MW: Now you say that Charlie Christian was one of your influences.

HE: Absolutely.

MW: Explain his influence and then talk about how the jazz guitar has evolved from that time.

HE: Well Charlie Christian, I mean when I first heard him I was just absolutely stunned you know. And I was a kid at that time and I could play a lot of notes, I mean a lot of notes, but they were worthless you know. So when I heard him and it got to me so then I started playing from playing a million notes to playing almost no notes. I mean each note had to be sent to me directly from heaven before I would consider playing it. And somewhere in there I've struck a happy medium. And Charlie changed the whole nature of the guitar. He played it sort of the way people have played guitaristic, sort of unlike that. Because he played more like a tenor saxophone would play you know. And he changed the whole course of solo guitaring. And you know that he died when he was 23. Yep. He could still be living and playing.

MW: That's another theme in jazz is the early and tragic death of some of its greatest players.

HE: Yeah well that's true. He had tuberculosis. And Jimmy Blanton died when he was 21, the bassist with Duke Ellington.

MW: How has the guitar playing itself evolved?

HE: Well the two main stylists I believe would be Charlie Christian and Django Reinhardt. And Charlie is more right in the face, you know bang, just lay it right in there. And Django sort of flirts with it. I don't mean that negatively. He plays a lot more notes than Charlie would play. And Charlie doesn't need to play that many because he can say it with just a few you see. So that's the two definite schools. And people can play a little bit

of both schools, but it usually comes from, you lean towards one school or another one. And then there are chordal players that play, when they have a solo they play chords. And maybe a couple of notes alone and then the chords. They are chord stylists. And there are not too many of those. The person who plays that best is George Van Eps. He made that style popular. He's a great guitarist. Still playing. He's even older than I am and that's hard to do.

MW: Tell us a little about that story you told us you were going to tell us about the Dorsey band.

HE: Oh, yeah. Well I went with Jimmy Dorsey and I played, I had two guitars. I had a rhythm guitar and an electric guitar. So there was a guitar feature in the band and I knew about it. So I got the record before I joined him and I learned it. And it was sort of difficult. It was a chord solo with a few single notes and it was the melody, so you had to play it pretty close to the way it was written you know. And I was a very bad reader in those days. And so we were on the job the first night and Jimmy gave me a couple of solos here and there. And then he pulled this number, "Sorghum Switch" I'll never forget it was number 43. And so he was about to beat it off and he says, "Oh, Herb, I'm sorry." He said, "This is a guitar solo and I understand it's rather difficult," he says. "Why don't you just take it home and we'll play it in a couple of nights now." I'm looking at it like I could read it see, because I had it memorized. And I said, "No, Jimmy," I says, "I think I can get through it, let's try it." So we did, and I played it perfectly — or almost perfectly. That was the night that the arrangers came in and brought the arrangements and then he'd tell them what they were going to do next. So he got all the arrangements together after that and he said, "I want you to write for Herb." He said, "I want him playing lead and harmony parts. He can read anything."

MW: So then did you have to back it up from that point on?

HE: Well yeah, but see I had him so buffaloed by that, that bringing the part that I couldn't sight read, which was often, I'd tell him that it didn't lay well, which is a bunch of nonsense. But he believed me. Because he thought if I couldn't play it right off then it was unplayable, you know. So it worked.

MW: How is doing studio work different from playing live?

HE: Well for me, and I think for most people that play studio work, it's just a way of earning a living. You can play with a big orchestra maybe backing a vocalist and then you could be doing a rock session. And go from there to a country session. So you just have to play all styles. And being a guitarist you have to play every instrument. You have to play the guitar, the banjo, the ukulele, the mandolin. And the only gratifying thing about it for me was the money because well not being a good reader I never enjoyed it. And the only

thing is you might play with a big orchestra maybe written by Johnny Mandel, you might play some nice music once in a while. But most of it is trash.

MW: You know in the studios if they're doing a multi-track recording, sometimes you get four or five chances at it.

HE: Yeah.

MW: How is that different from playing a night club where it's your turn to solo and that's it? The audience gets what you give that night.

HE: You mean in a jazz situation? Oh well first of all that's a lot of fun. I mean it can be a little nerve wracking if you're doing a big concert you know. But jazz players, they just love that. It's just what we do you know. And I know that we can make a mistake and turn it into a symphony, you know? That's what you have to learn to do.

MW: You talked about Charlie Christian and playing just a few notes but the right notes.

HE: Absolutely.

MW: That process, I have a term for that process, but I'd like you to expand on it and that is editing as much as creating.

HE: That's a good way to put it. Well it says it itself you know. But learning what to edit. That's the secret. Learning. And once you learn to edit like that then your melodies seem to get a lot stronger for some reason. I can tell by the audience reaction if I'm playing really good. And when you're playing good it's more melodic. That's what Lester Young, Prez, used to say. He called everybody "lady" like "Lady Ellis," he'd say, well we were playing on the stage and if I played particularly well he'd say, "Sing me a song, Lady Ellis."

MW: Do you have any other interesting stories with musicians that you've played with? And you've played with some greats.

HE: Oh I know I have I'm just trying to think. No, well if I think of one I'll come up with it.

MW: In the meantime tell us about what it was like to be a musician in some of the earlier years and kind of what the pay was like.

HE: In the earlier years? Well I was with Glen Grey, you probably don't even remember that name but that was an orchestra, and they played pretty well. And then when I went with Jimmy I made more and this is back in the '40s, you know, the early '40s. And I finally got to making, now this will seem ridiculous, $175 a week. But back at that time that was big money you know. And then I joined Oscar and my price went up some. But I'm just amazed, and when we'd travel with Oscar in Jazz at the Philharmonic in Europe, Norman had us booked at the very best hotels. And we could afford it on the money we made. Of course now that's a different ball game. I don't know if we'd be able to stay there or not.

MW: Describe how things are for you now.

HE: They are very good. There is something to be said for playing as long as I have. You know I'm very blessed. The Lord has blessed me. I don't have arthritis and my health is good, so I play about half the time now. And even if I didn't have to play financially I'd still play because I love it. It's what I do. It keeps me young, or thinking I'm young anyway.

MW: I want to ask you about what it must feel like to have a guitar named after you.

HE: Oh, that's a real great feeling. And even better is a lot of people like the guitar and they buy it, not in the same way that they'd buy a rock guitar, but it does pretty well for guitarists. And I'm very proud of the fact. It makes you feel great, it really does.

MW: How did the Gibson company, what questions did they ask you in building the guitar?

HE: They asked me, you know, what style I wanted. And they had a guitar that I played since 1953 that mine is very similar. That was an ES 175, and they called mine the Herb Ellis ES 165. And the only difference really is that the ES 175 is made out of plywood and mine is made out of real wood you know. It's just a better quality guitar. And it's pretty reasonable too.

MW: Are there young players today that you think try to play like you?

HE: I couldn't name but there are quite a few, you'd be amazed. And that's really a compliment. I wish I could think of some of them, but it's hard for me to think of what I had for breakfast this morning.

MW: Delightful. Tell us, another time you said you were going to tell us a story about where you didn't get paid at all, is that it?

HE: When I didn't get paid at all? You must have me mixed up with somebody. I don't remember that. I didn't get paid at all. I think if I didn't get paid at all I'd remember it. I've gotten so little that it's almost like not getting paid at all.

MW: So who is a guitarist — name a couple of guitarists on the scene that you see coming up that are continuing to breathe life into guitar playing.

HE: Al Cohn's son, Joe Cohn plays very well. And oh, Bucky Pizzarelli's son John, John Pizzarelli. He's kind of a star now, he sings, you know, he's getting really popular. And he plays real good. And if I think of any more, there are a lot of them but I just, I don't keep them readily at hand anyway. That's about all I know about everything.

MW: Well I just would like to ask you then, if you would give us a word of wisdom, if you had a word to say to young guitarists coming up, wanting to involve themselves in this music. What would it be?

HE: You mean musically? I would tell them that it's necessary, vital that they learn to play what they sing. You know when you're humming along with what you're playing you know. Joe Pass did it. Wes Montgomery did it. Clark Terry does it — all the good — Oscar does it, Ray Brown does it. Anybody who plays, you can't tell horn players,

because they've got something in their mouth. But ask them, and they're playing what they're singing, you know? And that way you make your own music, see? Because you're singing it. And another thing, you won't sing a bunch of silly stuff. You might play a bunch of silly stuff, but you won't sing about [scats] and so it really is the one thing that I say is absolutely vital.

MW: So that music is coming out of you.

HE: Absolutely. Yeah.

MW: That is marvelous. That is marvelous. Well we've had a marvelous interview here with just a champion of the guitar, Herb Ellis, recording for Hamilton Jazz Archives. Thank you.

HE: Hey, thank you.